

FILM MAKING AND RADIO PODCASTING CD23731
REPORT

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BONAFIDE CERTIFICATE

Certified that this report titled “THE EXCUSE” is the Bonafide work of V.J. LAKSHNAN (231701030) who carried out the work under my supervision. Certified further that to the best of my knowledge the work reported herein does not form part of any other thesis or dissertation on the basis of which a degree or award was conferred on an earlier occasion on this or any other candidate.

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CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

Film making is a creative form of visual communication that brings together storytelling, acting, cinematography, sound, lighting and editing to present an idea or experience to an audience. A short film tells a complete story in a limited duration, so a clear concept and the effective use of every scene are essential. Radio podcasting, on the other hand, communicates a story only through audio elements such as narration, dialogue, music, sound effects and silence. Both forms depend on careful planning, creativity and clear storytelling.

The project titled “The Excuse” is a short motivational comedy developed as part of the Film Making and Radio Podcasting course (CD23731). The story follows three friends, Sanjeeve, Supreet and Harish Babu, who decide to change their lifestyle and plan to visit a park at 6 AM the following morning. When the alarm rings, only Babu wakes up and goes to the park alone, while the other two continue sleeping. The friends later discuss what went wrong, decide to try again, and finally succeed in visiting the park together and jogging.

The film is built on an everyday situation that many students and young people recognise: making a good decision at night and finding it difficult to act on it the next morning. Instead of elaborate sets or equipment, the project relies on two simple locations, a room and a park, and on the performances of the three friends. The film closes with a motivational message about taking the first step. A team of five members handled the story, screenplay, direction, acting and editing, and the story is also planned to be retold as an audio-only radio podcast.

CHAPTER 2

PROJECT OVERVIEW

The central idea of The Excuse is that the biggest obstacle to a better lifestyle is often not the lack of ability, but the delay that comes before the first step. The film begins in a completely ordinary setting: three friends are together in a room, with Sanjeeve working on his laptop while Harish Babu and Supreet use their phones. This familiar opening allows the audience to recognise the situation immediately.

The story progresses through a series of small, relatable moments. Supreet raises the idea of changing their lifestyle, the friends agree to visit a park at 6 AM the next day, and the alarm the next morning tests their decision. Babu's effort to wake the others, his solo visit to the park, and the phone conversation that connects him with his friends in the room show the gap between making a plan and following it. When Babu returns and asks why the others did not come, the friends decide once again to visit the park the following morning, and this time all three reach it.

The film uses only two main locations, a room and a park, and three main characters, which keeps the production simple. The team used an iPhone mounted on a tripod for recording, available room lighting and natural daylight for the scenes, and Adobe After Effects for editing. The film ends with a motivational quote that states its message directly, and a radio podcast adaptation of the same story has been planned as part of the course requirement.

CHAPTER 3

TITLE – THE EXCUSE

The title “The Excuse” refers to the reasons people give themselves to postpone something they already know is worth doing. The three friends in the film are not against changing their lifestyle; they agree with the idea and even fix a time for it. The difficulty begins only when it is time to act, and this is the situation that the title points to.

The title is also a light comment on human behaviour. Delaying a good habit is easy, and an excuse can always be found, but taking the first step is what actually changes things. The single word “excuse” also reflects the tone of the film, which treats the friends’ behaviour with humour rather than criticism. By the end, the title gains a second meaning, because the closing quote tells the audience not to wait for motivation before starting. In this way, “The Excuse” describes the friends’ delay and also the idea that the film asks the viewer to move beyond.

CHAPTER 4

GENRE

The film belongs to the motivational comedy genre. The comedy comes from a situation that many people find familiar: agreeing enthusiastically to a plan at night and then failing to follow it in the morning. The motivational element comes from the way the story develops, as the friends discuss what went wrong, try again and finally complete the activity they had planned.

Unlike a serious drama about self-improvement, *The Excuse* does not present its characters as failures. The humour arises from the contrast between the friend who wakes up and goes to the park alone and the two who stay asleep, and from the conversations in which the friends talk about the plan they did not follow. The message is delivered gently and only becomes explicit in the closing quote.

The major elements of the genre used in the film are:

- A relatable everyday situation among friends
- The contrast between a friend who acts and friends who delay
- Conversational, dialogue-based humour
- A phone conversation connecting two locations
- A repeated plan that leads to a successful second attempt
- A closing motivational message

CHAPTER 5

OBJECTIVES

The main objective of the project is to create an engaging short film with a simple production setup, based on a relatable situation and a clear message. The project also aims to give practical experience of the complete film-making process, from story and screenplay to recording, dubbing and editing, and to explore how the same story can be adapted for a radio podcast.

The specific objectives are:

- To develop an original story with a clear motivational message.
- To write a screenplay and revise it during production.
- To direct and perform simple scenes in two locations.
- To record the film using an iPhone mounted on a tripod.
- To use available room lighting and natural daylight effectively.
- To combine live audio, separate recordings, dubbing and background music.
- To edit the film using Adobe After Effects.
- To work as a team with clearly divided responsibilities.
- To plan an audio-only adaptation of the story as a radio podcast.

CHAPTER 6

STORY DEVELOPMENT

The story of *The Excuse* was developed by V.J. Lakshnan from a simple observation: many people decide to improve their lifestyle but delay the first step with small reasons. The idea was kept simple so that the film could depend on natural conversation and performance rather than on a complicated plot or expensive resources.

The original screenplay was written for a film of about four minutes, with three characters named Arjun, Vicky and Karthi and seven scenes set in a house room and a park. During production, the story was reworked into the version that was actually filmed. The characters became Sanjeeve, Supreet and Harish Babu respectively, and some scenes and dialogues of the screenplay were modified or removed. For example, in the screenplay the friend who wakes up early calls his friends after getting ready, whereas in the filmed version he goes to the park alone and speaks to them by phone from there.

The final version of the story is organised into six scenes and a closing message. The first part shows the decision and the failure to follow it, the middle part shows the phone conversation and Babu's return, and the last part shows the second attempt, which succeeds. The closing quote was retained from the screenplay because it states the central message of the film directly.

CHAPTER 7

STORY SYNOPSIS

The film opens in a room where three friends are spending time together. Sanjeeve is working on his laptop, while Harish Babu is relaxing and using his phone. Supreet is also using his phone. The atmosphere is casual and familiar, and it establishes the easy friendship between the three characters.

Supreet then introduces the idea of changing their lifestyle. The friends discuss the idea among themselves and agree that they should start doing something different. They decide to visit a park at 6 AM the following morning.

The next morning, the alarm rings. Harish Babu wakes up and tries to wake Sanjeeve and Supreet, but they continue sleeping. Since his friends do not get up, Babu decides to go to the park alone. After reaching the park, he calls his friends, and a conversation takes place between Babu at the park and Sanjeeve and Supreet in the room. The audio connects the two locations.

Babu then returns to the room and asks the others why they did not come to the park. The three friends talk about it and, instead of giving up, decide once again to visit the park the following morning.

On the next morning, all three friends arrive at the park. They decide to jog, interact with one another, and eventually sit together on a bench. The film ends with the motivational quote: “DON’T WAIT FOR MOTIVATION. TAKE THE FIRST STEP. START FIRST. MOTIVATION WILL FOLLOW.” The story therefore moves from a plan that is made but not followed to a plan that is finally carried out.

CHAPTER 8

CHARACTERS

The Excuse has three main characters, played by three members of the team. Their names in the film are Sanjeeve, Supreet and Harish Babu. In the original screenplay they were named Arjun, Vicky and Karthi respectively. The characters are close friends who spend their time together in the same room, and the story is driven by the difference in how each of them responds to the decision they make together.

Sanjeeve, played by Sanjeev R.V., is first seen working on a laptop while his friends relax with their phones. He agrees to the plan of visiting the park, but when the alarm rings the next morning he continues sleeping. The character was originally written as a lazy and funny person who is creative in making excuses. In the filmed version, he is shown as a friend who supports the idea but does not act on it at first.

Supreet, played by R.V. Supreet, is the friend who introduces the idea of changing their lifestyle. He wants an improvement in their routine, but like Sanjeeve he does not get up when the alarm rings. The character, originally named Vicky, represents a person who wants to become better but keeps postponing the first step. In the final park scene, he joins the others in jogging.

Harish Babu, referred to as Babu and played by Harish Babu himself, is the friend who follows the plan. He wakes up when the alarm rings, tries to wake his friends and, when they do not get up, goes to the park on his own. He later asks his friends why they did not come. Originally named Karthi, the character was written as a practical and straightforward person who prefers action to speeches. In the film, Babu does not give up after the first attempt, and all three friends go to the park together the next morning.

CHAPTER 9

SCENE DEVELOPMENT

9.1 Scene 1 – Opening

The film opens inside a room where the three friends are together. Sanjeeve is working on a laptop, Harish Babu is relaxing and using his phone, and Supreet is also using his phone. The scene is recorded with the available room lighting and introduces the characters and their relationship in a calm and everyday manner.

9.2 Scene 2 – Lifestyle Change

Supreet introduces the idea of changing their lifestyle. The friends discuss the idea among themselves and agree to it. They decide to visit a park at 6 AM the following morning. This scene sets up the plan on which the rest of the story depends and prepares the audience for the contrast that follows.

9.3 Scene 3 – Morning Alarm

The next morning, an alarm rings in the room. Harish Babu wakes up and tries to wake Sanjeeve and Supreet, but they continue sleeping. Since neither of them gets up, Babu decides to go to the park alone. The scene shows the difference between deciding to do something and actually doing it.

9.4 Scene 4 – Phone Conversation

Babu reaches the park and calls his friends. A conversation takes place between Babu at the park and Sanjeeve and Supreet in the room. The audio connects the two locations, so that the audience follows the exchange as one conversation even though the characters are in different places.

9.5 Scene 5 – Babu Returns

Babu returns to the room and asks the others why they did not come to the park. A conversation takes place between the three friends about the morning that did not go as planned. Instead of abandoning the idea, they again decide to visit the park the following morning. The scene brings the three characters back together and forms the turning point of the story.

9.6 Scene 6 – Final Park Visit

The next morning, all three friends arrive at the park. They decide to jog and interact with one another as they do so. Eventually, they sit together on a bench. The scene is recorded in natural daylight and shows the friends finally completing the activity they had planned, giving a visual contrast to the earlier indoor scenes.

9.7 Final Scene – Motivational Quote

The film concludes with the motivational quote: “DON’T WAIT FOR MOTIVATION. TAKE THE FIRST STEP. START FIRST. MOTIVATION WILL FOLLOW.” The quote states the message of the film in words after the story has already shown it through the actions of the three friends.

CHAPTER 10

CLIMAX AND ENDING

The climax of *The Excuse* occurs when the three friends, after failing on the first morning, reach the park together. The story builds up to this moment through the plan made in the room, the alarm that two of the friends ignore, Babu's solo visit and the conversation after his return. Because the friends decide again to visit the park the following morning, the audience expects a second attempt, and the scene in which all three arrive and begin to jog releases the tension created by the first failure.

The ending follows in a calm and simple manner. After jogging, the friends sit together on a bench, and the film concludes with the motivational quote: "DON'T WAIT FOR MOTIVATION. TAKE THE FIRST STEP. START FIRST. MOTIVATION WILL FOLLOW." Rather than ending only on a light moment, the film ends with a clear message that connects the story to the viewer's own life. The friends started by simply going to the park, and the quote states that this first step matters more than waiting for the right feeling.

CHAPTER 11

CINEMATOGRAPHY

The film was recorded using an iPhone mounted on a tripod. A phone camera was suitable because it is easily available, simple to operate and sufficient for a short film with two locations. Mounting it on a tripod kept the camera steady during recording, which gave the shots a stable and clean appearance and allowed the team to concentrate on the performances.

The framing in the room scenes was intended to show the three friends and their activities clearly, such as Sanjeev working on the laptop while the others use their phones. In the park scenes, the camera was used to show the friends arriving, jogging and later sitting together on the bench. The same camera setup was used in both locations, which helped to maintain a consistent visual look across the film. No other camera equipment was used in the production.

CHAPTER 12

LIGHTING

The Excuse was filmed without any additional lighting equipment. The indoor scenes in the room were recorded using the available room lighting, and the outdoor scenes in the park were recorded in natural daylight.

Using the room lighting kept the indoor scenes natural and true to an ordinary room, which suits the casual and familiar mood of the opening and of the conversations between the friends. It also allowed the team to record without long lighting setups. The natural daylight in the park gave the outdoor scenes a fresh and bright appearance that matches the morning setting and the positive mood of the final park visit. The difference between the indoor lighting and the outdoor daylight also helps the audience notice the move from the friends' indoor routine to the outdoor activity they finally carry out.

CHAPTER 13

SOUND DESIGN

Sound is important in The Excuse because much of the story is told through conversation. The audio of the film is built from four sources: live audio recorded during filming, separately recorded audio, additional dubbing audio for the character dialogues, and downloaded background music. Not all of the audio was recorded separately, and the different sources were combined during editing.

The alarm in the morning scene marks the change from the plan made at night to the test of that plan the next day. The phone conversation between the park and the room depends on audio, as the voices of Sanjeeve and Supreet in the room are connected with Babu's voice from the park. The downloaded background music was added to support the mood of the scenes without covering the dialogue.

Important sound elements used in the film include:

- Live audio recorded during filming
- Separately recorded audio
- Dubbing audio for the character dialogues
- Downloaded background music
- The morning alarm sound
- Conversation between the three friends in the room
- Phone conversation connecting the park and the room

CHAPTER 14

EDITING TECHNIQUES

Editing of The Excuse was carried out using Adobe After Effects. The recorded footage of the room and park scenes was arranged in the order of the story, beginning with the opening in the room and ending with the final park scene and the motivational quote. The film was edited by V.J. Lakshnan, Sanjeev R.V. and Derick Dilip.

The editing also involved working with several types of audio. The live audio recorded during filming, the separately recorded audio and the additional dubbing audio for the character dialogues were placed along with the footage, and the downloaded background music was added beneath the scenes. Special attention was needed in the phone conversation, where the audio had to connect Babu at the park with Sanjeev and Supreet in the room. Cuts between the room and the park, and between the first attempt and the second attempt, help the audience follow the passage of time from one morning to the next. Adobe After Effects was the only editing software used for the project.

CHAPTER 15

USE OF PROPS AND LOCATION

The project was produced using only two main locations: a room and a park. Both locations were easily accessible, which kept the production simple while still giving a clear difference between the indoor and outdoor scenes. The room was used for the opening, the lifestyle discussion, the morning alarm, the friends' side of the phone conversation and Babu's return. The park was used for Babu's solo visit, his phone call and the final visit of all three friends.

The major props and location elements are:

- Laptop
- Mobile phones
- Room for the indoor scenes
- Park for the outdoor scenes
- Open area in the park for jogging
- Park bench

The small number of props keeps the focus on the performances and the conversations between the characters rather than on production complexity.

CHAPTER 16

RADIO PODCAST ADAPTATION

A radio podcast adaptation of The Excuse has been planned for this course. The podcast has not yet been recorded or produced. It will follow the same storyline, the same three characters and the same overall message as the short film. In an audio-only format, the events that the film shows visually will have to be communicated through dialogue, narration and sound effects.

In the film, the audience sees Sanjeeve working on his laptop, Harish Babu and Supreet using their phones, and the three friends together in the room. In the podcast, a short narration can introduce the room and the friends, supported by simple sound effects, so that the listener can imagine the setting. The park scenes can similarly be presented through light outdoor sounds and the sound of jogging, along with the dialogue of the characters.

The phone conversation between Babu and his friends is well suited to audio, since the two locations are already connected through voices. The alarm can be used as a clear audio cue to mark the morning, and the final motivational quote can be delivered as a closing line so that the message of the film is retained in the podcast.

CHAPTER 17

RADIO PODCAST SCRIPT APPROACH

The podcast script will be adapted from the screenplay and the final film, keeping the same order of events: the friends' discussion in the room, the decision to visit the park at 6 AM, the morning alarm, Babu's solo visit and phone call, his return to the room, the second decision and the final visit to the park. Sound descriptions will be written into the script so that the sequence of events is clear.

Since the listener cannot see the characters, information that is visible in the film will be added through short narration and through the dialogue itself. For example, the characters can mention what they are doing, and a narrator can briefly announce the change of place between the room and the park. Narration will be kept short so that the conversation remains the main focus of the podcast.

The dialogue will be kept natural and conversational, in the same style as the film. Pauses and sound effects will be marked in the script to show where the alarm, the phone call and the change of location occur. The podcast will end with the same motivational quote as the film, so that the message reaches the listener in the same form.

CHAPTER 18

VOICE AND AUDIO PERFORMANCE

In the radio podcast, voice performance will carry the story, since the audience cannot see facial expressions or actions. The three characters will need clearly different voices and speaking styles so that listeners can identify who is speaking. The team's experience of dubbing the character dialogues for the film will be useful for this stage.

Babu's voice should sound active and energetic in the morning scenes, while Sanjeeve's and Supreet's voices should sound relaxed and sleepy when they are being woken. During the phone conversation, the voices of the friends in the room should sound different from Babu's voice from the park, so that the listener understands the two locations. In the final park scene, the voices should become more energetic to show that the friends have finally started the activity.

The following elements are important:

- Clear and distinct voices for the three characters
- Natural and conversational dialogue delivery
- A vocal difference between the sleepy and the active friends
- Clear audio for the phone conversation between two locations
- Light background music to support the mood
- A clean recording with minimal noise

CHAPTER 19

PRODUCTION PROCESS

The production of The Excuse was carried out in three stages: pre-production, production and post-production. Five members took part in the project, and the responsibilities were divided as follows: V.J. Lakshnan handled the story, screenplay, direction and editing; Sanjeev R.V. handled acting and editing; Harish Babu and R.V. Supreet handled acting; and Derick Dilip handled editing.

During pre-production, the story idea was developed into a screenplay with three characters and two locations, a room and a park. The screenplay was written for a film of about four minutes with seven scenes. The locations, the characters and the basic requirements for recording were also decided at this stage. As the film was made with easily available resources, no special equipment was arranged.

During production, the scenes were recorded in the room and in the park using an iPhone mounted on a tripod. Available room lighting was used for the indoor scenes and natural daylight for the outdoor scenes. During this stage, some scenes and dialogues of the screenplay were changed or removed, and the characters were named Sanjeeve, Supreet and Harish Babu in the film. Live audio was recorded during filming, and additional audio was recorded separately for use in the edit.

During post-production, the footage was edited in Adobe After Effects. The scenes were arranged in order, the separately recorded audio and the dubbing audio were combined with the live audio, and the downloaded background music was added. The motivational quote was placed at the end of the film. The radio podcast adaptation is planned as a separate task and is not yet a part of this production process.

CHAPTER 20

CHALLENGES FACED

One of the main challenges was that the film was made by a small team in which members took more than one responsibility. V.J. Lakshnan handled the story, screenplay, direction and editing, and Sanjeev R.V. handled both acting and editing, so the work had to be planned carefully to allow the same people to perform different roles at different stages.

Combining different types of audio was another challenge. The film uses live audio recorded during filming, separately recorded audio, dubbing for the character dialogues and downloaded background music. These had to be matched with the visuals and balanced so that the dialogues remained clear and the background music did not cover them. The phone conversation between the park and the room needed particular care, as two locations had to be connected through audio.

The film also had to be adapted from the original screenplay during production. Some scenes were modified or removed and the characters were renamed, so the story had to remain clear and continuous even after these changes. In addition, recording with a single iPhone on a tripod, using only available room lighting and natural daylight, meant that the team had to work within simple conditions rather than depending on additional equipment.

CHAPTER 21

LEARNING OUTCOMES

Through this project, several practical skills were developed, including story and screenplay writing, direction, acting in front of a camera, recording with an iPhone and tripod, dubbing character dialogues, combining different audio sources and editing with Adobe After Effects.

The project also showed how a simple story with two locations and three characters can be told effectively without expensive resources. Working with available room lighting and natural daylight helped the team understand how lighting conditions affect the look of a scene, and working in a team of five members showed the importance of clearly divided responsibilities and coordination.

Planning the radio podcast adaptation provided an understanding of how visual scenes can be communicated through dialogue, narration and sound effects, and how the same story and message must be presented differently when the audience can only listen.

CHAPTER 22

EXPECTED OUTCOME

The final outcome of the project is a short motivational comedy film titled *The Excuse*, supported by a planned radio podcast adaptation of the same story. The film is expected to engage the audience through a relatable situation in which three friends struggle to follow their decision to change their lifestyle before finally starting it together.

The project is expected to demonstrate the practical use of storytelling, acting, simple cinematography, natural lighting, sound and editing. Its student-life setting and simple message are intended to make it easy for the audience to connect with the film, and the closing quote is expected to leave the viewer with a clear idea: do not wait for motivation, take the first step.

CHAPTER 23

CONCLUSION

The Excuse demonstrates how a small, everyday situation can be developed into a meaningful short film. The story begins with three friends deciding to change their lifestyle, shows how the decision is delayed when the morning arrives, and ends with all three friends visiting the park and jogging together, followed by a motivational message.

The project combined story and screenplay writing, direction, acting, recording with an iPhone on a tripod, sound work and editing in Adobe After Effects. The use of two locations, three characters, available room lighting and natural daylight shows that an effective short film can be made with simple resources when the story is clear and the team works together.

The planned radio podcast adaptation shows how the same story can be reshaped for an audio-only medium by using dialogue, narration and sound effects in place of visuals.

Overall, The Excuse provided practical experience in both film making and radio podcasting, and it reinforced the message at the centre of the film: the first step matters more than waiting for the right motivation.

*“DON’T WAIT FOR MOTIVATION. TAKE THE FIRST STEP. START FIRST.
MOTIVATION WILL FOLLOW.”*